

UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

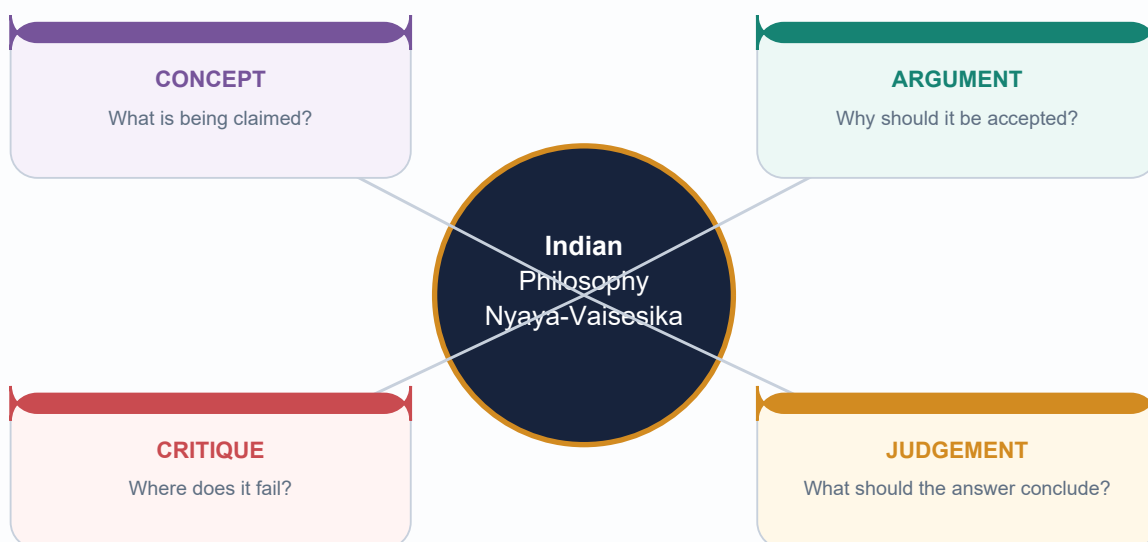
Indian Philosophy: Nyaya-Vaisesika

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Indian Philosophy

Visual learning edition: central maps, argument flows, comparisons and PYQ frameworks

Syllabus: Theory of Categories; Theory of Appearance; Theory of Pramana; Self; Liberation; God; Proofs for the Existence of God; Theory of Causation; Atomistic Theory of Creation.

Direct-source base: Chatterjee and Datta, Nyaya and Vaisesika chapters (local PDF pp. 135-204); C. D. Sharma, Vaisesika and Nyaya chapters (printed pp. 163-226); Radhakrishnan, Indian Philosophy Vol. II, Nyaya and Vaisesika chapters. Cross-checked with Paper I PYQs, 2022-2025.



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Central Mind Map: Realism, Knowledge, and Liberation

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Nyaya supplies the method of valid knowledge and argument; Vaishesika supplies a categorial and atomistic ontology. Their later alliance yields a realist, pluralist system in which true knowledge removes error and suffering.

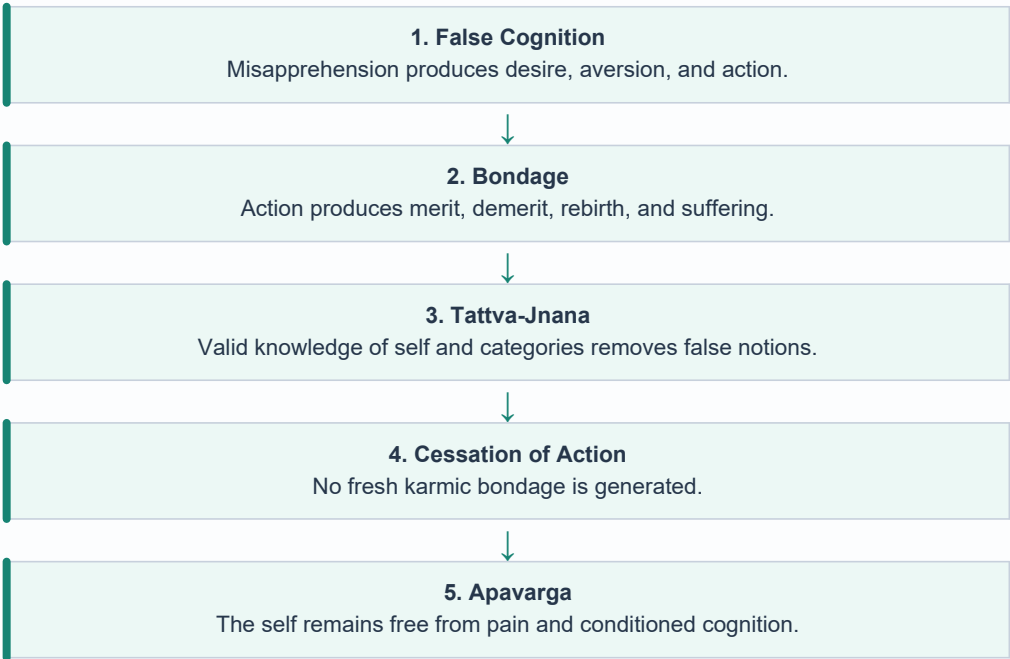
The traditions began with different emphases and should not be collapsed: Nyaya centers pramana and debate, while Vaishesika centers padartha and natural ontology.

NYAYA-VAISESIKA MASTER MAP

REAL OBJECTS ARE KNOWN THROUGH VALID MEANS

Pramana Perception, inference, comparison, and testimony.	Categories Substance, quality, action, universal, particularity, inherence, absence.
Self Enduring individual substance; consciousness is an adventitious quality.	Causation Effect is a new beginning: asatkaryavada or arambhavada.
Atomism Eternal atoms combine into non-eternal composite objects.	God and Liberation Isvara orders atoms and karma; apavarga ends suffering.

FROM ERROR TO APAVARGA



MEMORY HOOK

NYAYA KNOWS; VAISESIKA CATALOGUES. Together: pramana -> padartha -> true self -> release.

CONCEPT LINKS

Core Concept	Linked Doctrine	Exam Value
Real universals	Buddhist apoha / nominalism	Mind-independent common nature versus exclusion.
Asatkaryavada	Samkhya satkaryavada	New effect versus pre-existent effect.
Paratah-pramanya	Mimamsa svatah-pramanya	Extrinsic versus intrinsic validity.
Self as substance	Advaita self as consciousness	Consciousness as quality versus essence.

MAINS ANGLE

Nyaya-Vaisesika turns liberation into an epistemic project grounded in a robust realist ontology.

STUDY LINK

Official syllabus item 15; divide answers into Nyaya epistemology and Vaisesika ontology before showing the synthesis.

HIGH

Technical Terms: Categories and Pramanas

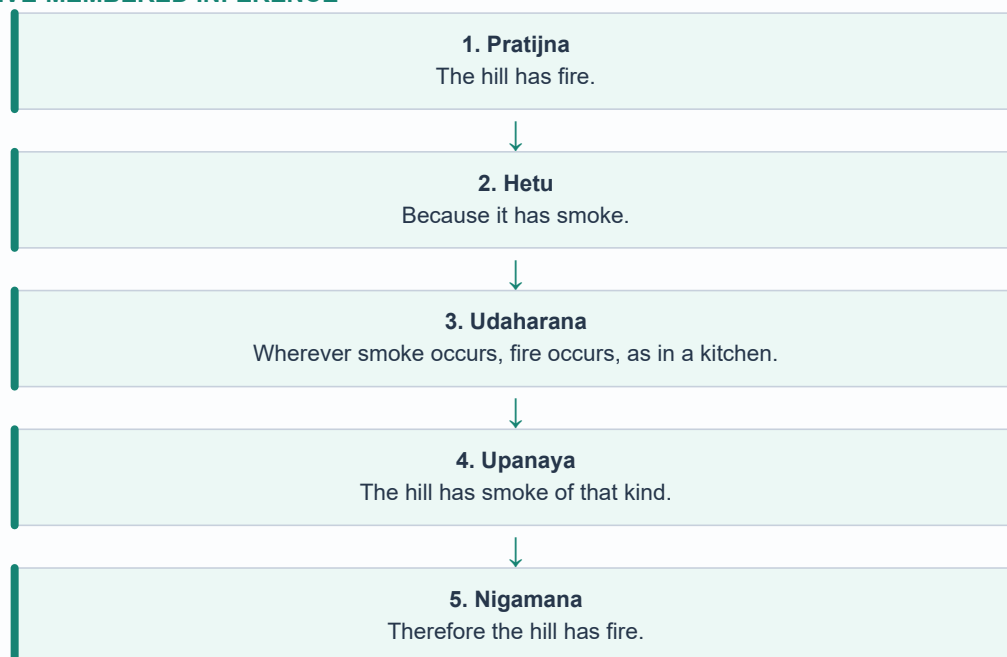
Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Vaisesika classifies everything knowable under padarthas, while Nyaya classifies the reliable routes by which those objects are known.

KEY DATA

Term	Meaning	UPSC Use
Dravya	Substance; includes elements, space, time, self, and mind.	Substratum of qualities and actions.
Guna	Quality that inheres in substance.	Explain dependence without identity.
Karma	Motion or action belonging to substance.	Physical change.
Samanya	Real universal common to many particulars.	2022 ontological-status route.
Visesa	Ultimate differentiator of eternal entities.	Explains plurality of atoms and selves.
Samavaya	Eternal inherence linking inseparable relata.	Whole-part, quality-substance, universal-particular.
Abhava	Non-existence with a counterpositive.	Prior, posterior, mutual, and absolute absence.
Pratyaksa	Perception generated through appropriate contact.	Gautama definition; ordinary and extraordinary.
Anumana	Inference from a sign through known invariable relation.	Five-member syllogism and fallacies.
Upamana	Knowledge through comparison.	Distinct Nyaya pramana.
Sabda	Reliable verbal testimony.	Human testimony and Vedic authority.

NYAYA FIVE-MEMBERED INFERENCE**STATIC THEORY**

- **Perception:** distinguish indeterminate and determinate cognition, and ordinary from extraordinary perception.
- **Inference:** requires a valid hetu, its presence in the subject, and vyapti established without defeating conditions.
- **Abhava:** absence is not sheer nothing; it is known as absence of a determinate counterpositive in a locus.
- **Theory of appearance:** anyathakhyati treats error as a real remembered object mislocated in the present locus.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Classical Vaisheshika begins with six categories; abhava is admitted later as a seventh.
2. Nyaya accepts four pramanas.
3. Samavaya is invoked where separation would destroy the relation.

MAINS ANGLE

The category scheme is a realist answer to how language, thought, and the world share stable structure.

STUDY LINK

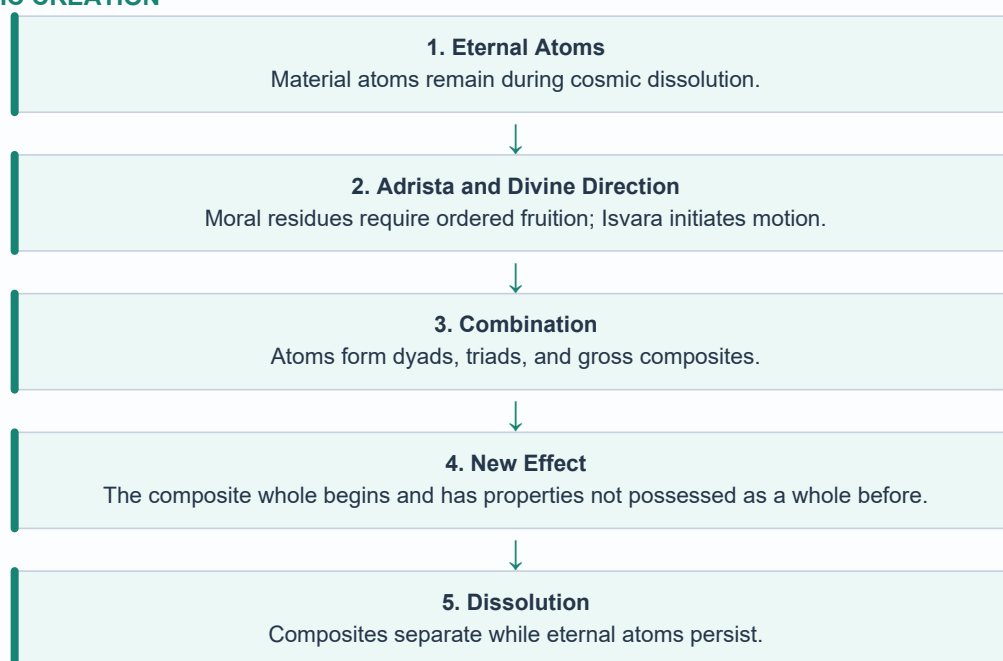
Use categories for Vaisheshika questions and pramana structure for Nyaya questions.

HIGH**Self, Appearance, Causation, and Atomistic Creation**Paper I
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The enduring self explains recognition, memory, desire, and moral continuity. The physical world is constructed from eternal atoms, while composite effects begin when causes combine.

KEY DATA

Doctrine	Nyaya-Vaisesika Account	Contrast
Self	Eternal individual substance; cognition, desire, pleasure, pain, and volition are qualities.	Advaita: consciousness is the self's essence.
Manas	Atomic internal sense connecting self with one cognition at a time.	Explains non-simultaneous awareness.
Anyathakhyati	A real remembered object is presented in the wrong locus.	Mimamsa and Advaita theories of error.
Asatkaryavada	Effect does not pre-exist; production is a new beginning.	Samkhya satkaryavada.
Pragabhava	Prior non-existence of the effect before production.	Supports new-production theory.
Atoms	Eternal, indivisible atoms of earth, water, fire, and air.	Composite objects are non-eternal.
Apavarga	Cessation of pain and conditioned consciousness.	Criticized as stone-like liberation.

ATOMISTIC CREATION**STATIC THEORY**

- **Six routes to self:** memory, recognition, desire, aversion, effort, and coordinated cognition require an enduring subject.
- **Causation:** material, non-inherent, and efficient conditions jointly explain production.
- **Whole-part realism:** the cloth is a new whole inhering in threads, not merely a name for them.
- **Liberation:** knowledge removes defects and action; critics object that absence of consciousness and bliss is unattractive.

MEMORY HOOK

ATOMS PERSIST; WHOLES BEGIN. SELF PERSISTS; COGNITIONS BEGIN.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Consciousness is not eternally manifest in the self.
2. Pragabhava has no beginning but ends when the effect is produced.
3. Atomism needs an ordering account of initial motion and karmic distribution.

MAINS ANGLE

The system gains explanatory clarity from enduring substances, but pays the price of multiplying entities and relations.

STUDY LINK

Pair pragabhava with the Samkhya causation debate.

HIGH**God-Proofs and Strongest Criticism-Defence**

Paper I
Philosophy

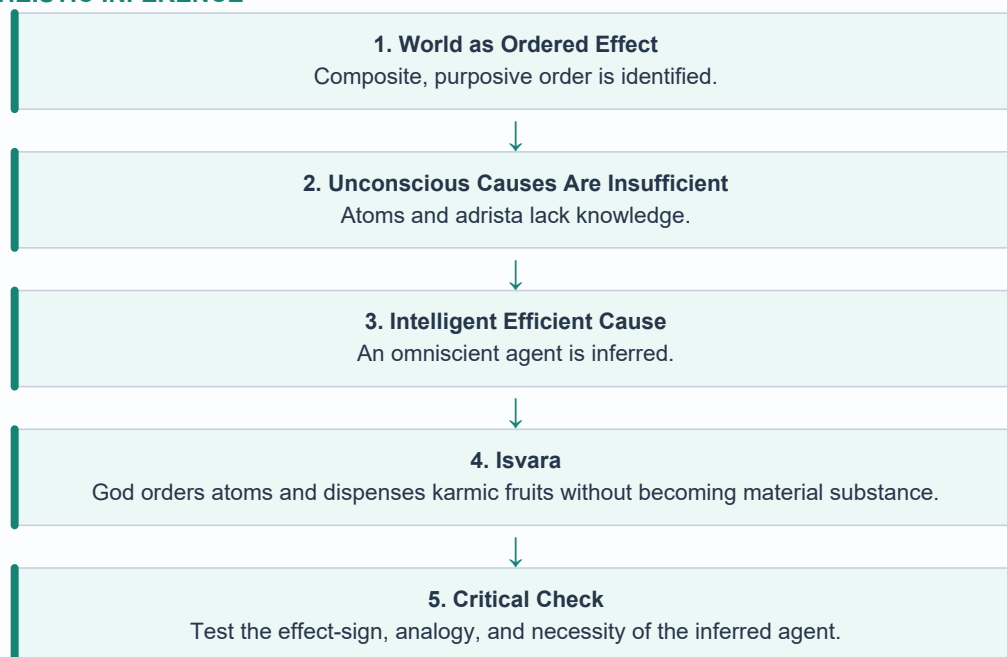
INTRO & ORIGIN

Later Nyaya argues to Isvara as an omniscient, eternal self who efficiently orders atoms, language, and karmic consequences. God is not the material cause.

KEY DATA

Proof / Criticism	Argument	Assessment
Karyat	The world is an effect composed of parts and requires an intelligent maker.	Depends on extending artifact reasoning to the cosmos.
Ayojanat	Unconscious atoms need direction for first combination.	Critics ask why natural capacities are insufficient.
Adrstat	Unconscious karmic residue cannot intelligently distribute results.	God is proposed as moral governor.
Padat / Sabdat	Word-meaning order and Vedic authority suggest an omniscient source.	Mimamsa rejects a divine author.
Dhrteh	Cosmic order and support require an intelligent sustainer.	May redescribe rather than prove order.
Strongest criticism	If every complex effect needs a maker, why exempt God, and how can an incorporeal self move atoms?	Challenges analogy and interaction.
Best defence	The inference is to a non-composite necessary intelligent cause, not another produced artifact.	Preserves the intended asymmetry, though premises remain contestable.

NYAYA THEISTIC INFERENCE



STATIC THEORY

- **Samkhya objection:** prakriti can evolve without a creator.
- **Mimamsa objection:** the Veda is authorless, and apurva can connect ritual with results.
- **Buddhist objection:** momentary causal series needs no permanent controller.
- **Nyaya defence:** blind causes may explain sequence but not rational coordination and moral allocation.

COMPARISON TABLE

Issue	Nyaya	Alternative
Material cause	Eternal atoms	Advaita: Brahman as material and efficient cause
Efficient cause	Isvara	Samkhya: no God required
Vedic authority	Omniscient author	Mimamsa: authorless eternity
Liberation	Cessation of pain	Vedanta: positive realization or communion

MAINS ANGLE

Nyaya theism is a cumulative explanatory inference, not a single demonstrative proof.

STUDY LINK

For God questions, state efficient-not-material cause before listing proofs.

HIGH

PYQ Routes and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks

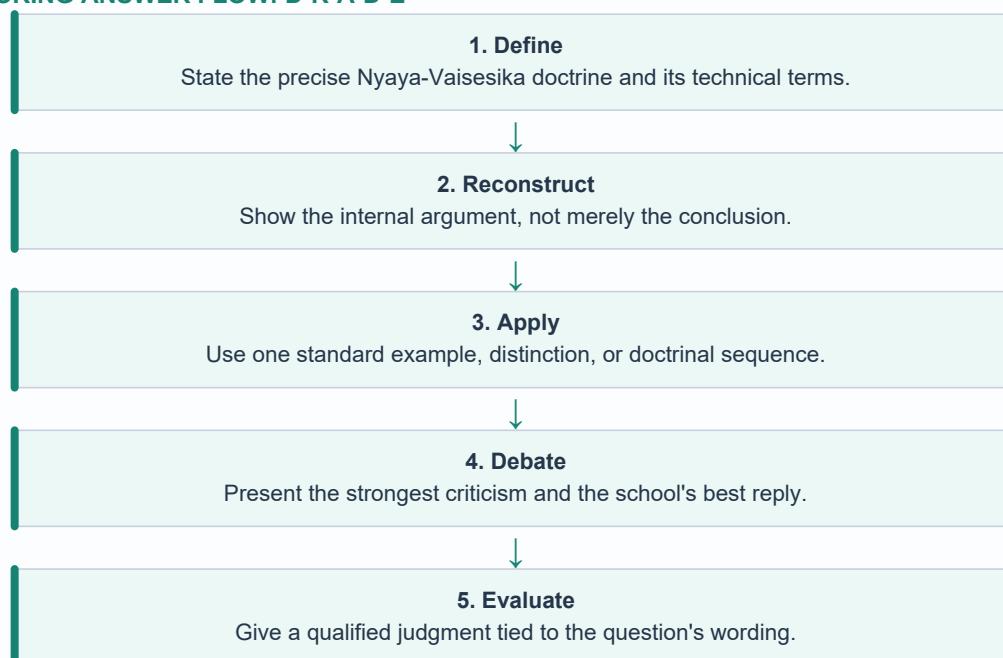
Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

UPSC repeatedly tests a narrow doctrine through comparison, internal tension, criticism, or an applied example. The answer should reconstruct the school's reasoning before evaluating it.

KEY DATA

Year / Marks	Verified PYQ Route	Core Demand
2022 / 10	Ontological status of samanya.	Real universal, inherence, Buddhist challenge.
2023 / 20	Fallacies of the middle term and valid hetu.	Inference structure and defects.
2023 / 15	Pragabhava against Samkhya causation.	Prior non-existence and new effect.
2024 / 10	Six reasons for existence of self.	Memory, desire, cognition, agency.
2024 / 10	Types of abhava through applied examples.	Counterpositive and four absences.
2025 / 20	Gautama's definition of perception.	Sense-object contact, non-verbal, non-errant, determinate issues.
2025 / 10	Nyaya-Vaisesika causation.	Asatkaryavada, causes, new whole.

HIGH-SCORING ANSWER FLOW: D-R-A-D-E**STATIC THEORY**

- **10 marks:** define the category or pramana, explain its function with one example, present one rival view.
- **15 marks:** reconstruct the inference or causal doctrine, add technical distinctions, then evaluate the opponent.
- **20 marks:** organize into definition, types, argument, fallacies/objections, inter-school debate, and a reasoned realist assessment.
- **Applied drill:** Infer fire from smoke, identify paksa, sadhya, hetu, vyapti, and a possible upadhi.
- **Applied drill:** Classify the absence in “the jar was not here before production” and distinguish it from mutual absence.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Write the Sanskrit technical term once, then explain it in plain language.
2. Separate exposition, criticism, defence, and final assessment.
3. Use comparison only where it clarifies the precise issue asked.
4. For statement questions, interpret the statement before presenting doctrine.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Nyaya and Vaisesika are identical from the beginning.

CORRECT: They begin with epistemic and ontological emphases and later converge. Shows historical precision.

WRONG: Abhava is absolute nothing.

CORRECT: It is determinate absence relative to a counterpositive and locus. Needed for applied PYQs.

WRONG: God is the material cause.

CORRECT: Atoms are material cause; Isvara is efficient cause. Avoid Vedanta confusion.

WRONG: Liberated self is blissful consciousness.

CORRECT: Classical account stresses cessation of pain and conditioned cognition. Address stone-like objection.

UPSC TRAPS AND CORRECTIONS

Common Trap	Correction	Answer Use
Nyaya and Vaisesika are identical from the beginning.	They begin with epistemic and ontological emphases and later converge.	Shows historical precision.
Abhava is absolute nothing.	It is determinate absence relative to a counterpositive and locus.	Needed for applied PYQs.
God is the material cause.	Atoms are material cause; Isvara is efficient cause.	Avoid Vedanta confusion.
Liberated self is blissful consciousness.	Classical account stresses cessation of pain and conditioned cognition.	Address stone-like objection.

MAINS ANGLE

Nyaya-Vaisesika is philosophically strongest when its pramana theory and ontology mutually support one another; its God and liberation doctrines remain more controversial than its realist analysis.

STUDY LINK

Revise the master map, doctrine table, criticism-defence grid, and PYQ routes together.